

THE QUIET CARE

A 30-Day Plan to Care for Your
Kids, Your Parents, and Your
Marriage Without Burning Out



S. Shharma

Introduction - The Marriage Nobody Names in the Sandwich Years

There is a marriage that nobody talks about.

It is not the marriage of the affair. It is not the marriage of the loud fight. It is not the marriage that ends in court.

It is the marriage of the sandwich years. The marriage where one partner has become the project manager of the family. The marriage where the bedtime conversations have become log-only. The marriage where the touch has become functional. The marriage where one partner has slowly disappeared into the work of caring for everyone except the marriage.

It is the marriage that, statistically, is the most common in midlife. It is the marriage that is at the highest risk of breaking. It is the marriage that, when it does break, almost no one talks about afterwards, because the marriage's breaking is buried under the work of the caregiving that nobody else was doing.

This book is for that marriage. The book is for the marriage that the sandwich years quietly take.

The Sandwich Years Are Real

Let me give you the numbers, because the numbers will tell you whether you are alone.

In the United States today, 23% of adults are in the sandwich generation - the generation simultaneously caring for their parents and their own children. Sixty-three million Americans are family caregivers. Of those, 29% are simultaneously caring for a parent and a child. The rate is highest in your forties - 54% of adults in their 40s are sandwiched. In the UK, six million workers aged 40-65 are in the sandwich generation. In Australia, 2.6 million unpaid caregivers. In Canada, the EU, the global Indian diaspora, the urban centers of Asia, the situation is the same: millions of people, in the prime of their working lives, simultaneously carrying the load of two generations.

The average caregiver spends 27 hours per week providing direct care. The average caregiver spends \$7,242 per year out of pocket. The average caregiver provides care for 5+ years. For a third of caregivers, the duration is 10+ years.

For some, the duration is 20+ years.

The sandwich years are not a season. The sandwich years are a *climate*. The sandwich years are a *decades-long* life. The sandwich years are the most demanding, the most emotionally expensive, the most under-discussed years a marriage can face.

The Marriage Nobody Names

I am a businessman with thirty years in corporate management, and I am a man who lived a quiet marriage and lost my wife. What I write about here is what I have lived, what I have read deeply about, and what the people I have known in these chapters have shared with me.

In my last book, *Still Married, Just Silent*, I wrote about the marriages that go quiet - the marriages that are functionally fine, where both partners are present, where the work-of-life is being done, but where the *conversation* has gone. The book was for the couples in the silent marriage.

This book is for the couples in the marriage that the caregiving years quietly take.

The pattern is different from the silent marriage. In the silent marriage, the conversation is gone but the work-of-life is still being shared. In the sandwich-years marriage, the work-of-life has been *replaced* - by the parent's care, by the adult child's care, by the medical appointments, by the sibling-coordination, by the medication management, by the project's project manager.

The marriage has not gone silent. The marriage has gone *functional*. The marriage has become a co-managed project. The marriage is now one more thing on the to-do list.

The marriage is in the crosshairs. The marriage is the largest casualty of the sandwich years. The marriage is the relationship that gets the least attention, the least care, the least time, the least protection.

Almost no book on caregiving names this. Almost no therapy focuses on this. Almost no support group addresses this. The books on caregiving focus on the parent. The books on marriage focus on the couple. The marriage *during* the caregiving years - the most important missing lens - is almost never the focus.

This book is that focus. This book is the lens.

Who This Book Is For

This book is for:

- The sandwich-generation caregiver who is married, partnered, or cohabiting, and who has begun to feel the distance in the marriage.
- The spouse of a sandwich-generation caregiver - the person who has been on the periphery of the work, and who has been feeling the loneliness of the marriage in the caregiving years.
- The sandwich-generation couple who knows something is wrong but doesn't have the language to name it.
- The sandwich-generation couple who has decided to stay married through the caregiving years and wants a manual for the work.
- The sandwich-generation adult child (with or without a partner) who is supporting an aging parent and who wants to understand the work better.
- The therapist, coach, or clergy member who is working with sandwich-generation couples and wants a structured framework.

This book is also, in a different way, for the caregiver who has lost a spouse - who has gone through the sandwich years alone, or who has been the spouse in a marriage that broke during the caregiving years. The book is, in that sense, also a *grief book* - the grief of the years that the sandwich took.

I write this with the personal knowledge of having been in the sandwich years myself. My wife of many years died of cancer. I was her primary caregiver. I had an adult child. I had a marriage that the caregiving years put under a strain I had not known a marriage could bear.

I write this with the knowledge of having been, in a sense, on both sides - the caregiver and the spouse, the project manager and the one being managed-for. I write this with the knowledge of having seen the marriage, in retrospect, be forged by the work, and also be marked by it.

This book is for the marriage in the middle of the work. This book is for the marriage that wants to survive. This book is for the marriage that, with the right scaffolding, can.

What This Book Will Do

This book will not make you a better caregiver. You are probably already a good one. You are probably a great one. You are probably the person everyone in your family calls first.

This book will help you survive the caregiving years without losing the things that actually matter:

- **Without losing your health.** The 58% of caregivers who report fair or poor health are telling you something. The 41% with high blood pressure are telling you something. The 5-7 year shorter lifespan of caregivers is telling you something.
- **Without losing your marriage.** The sandwich years are quietly the largest cause of marriage erosion in midlife. Nobody says this. This book says it.
- **Without losing your future.** The caregivers who go broke are not the ones who earn the least. They are the ones who did not plan. The sandwich years are 15-20 years. They cost an average of \$7,242 a year out of pocket. They cost the average caregiver \$324,000 in lifetime income lost.
- **Without losing yourself.** The question underneath all the questions of the sandwich years is the oldest one. **"What about me?"** You are allowed to ask. This book names it.

This book will give you a 30-day plan. A 90-day commitment. A 5-year dream. A Forever Plan. The same structured approach I used in *Still Married, Just Silent*, applied to the unique stresses of the sandwich years.

This book is also different from the silent marriage book. The sandwich years have their own dynamics - the parent, the adult child, the siblings, the work, the body, the money. Each of those is its own chapter. The marriage is the lens through which each of those is read.

The Honest Beginning

I am going to tell you, in this book, things that other books on caregiving won't tell you. I am going to tell you that the marriage often breaks. I am going to tell you that the caregiver often gets sick. I am going to tell you that the siblings usually don't help enough. I am going to tell you that your parent is going to die, and you are not going to be ready, and the grief is going to land on a marriage that is already in trouble.

I am going to tell you all of this because I have seen it. I have seen this place from the inside. I have seen what the caregiving years do to a marriage, and I have seen what the caregiving years can become when the marriage is named and protected.

I will also tell you that the marriage can survive this. The caregiver can survive this. The siblings can be brought back in. The parent can be cared for with

grace. The adult child can be helped without being hosted forever. The body can be protected. The future can be planned. The marriage can come out the other side of the sandwich years forged, not broken.

But the marriage has to be named. The marriage has to be protected. The marriage has to be worked on. The marriage is the work, alongside the caregiving.

This book is the manual for that work.

The First Exercise

Before chapter 1, take three minutes.

On a piece of paper, write down, honestly:

1. The last time you and your partner had a conversation that was not about the caregiving, the kids, the work, or the household. Be specific. Was it a week ago? A month ago? A year ago?
2. Three sentences you have not said to your partner in over a year. Sentences you have actively avoided saying. Could be an apology. Could be a need. Could be a thank you. Could be a hurt. Could be a fear. Could be *"I miss us."*
3. The thing about your marriage you have not told anyone. The real thing. The thing that sits in your chest at 3 a.m.
4. The one thing your partner does that, if they stopped, would mean the marriage is over.
5. The one thing your partner does that, if they kept doing, would save the marriage.

The exercise is the start. Don't share it yet. We'll use it in chapter 8.

Now - to chapter 1.

- "The sandwich years are the most demanding, the most emotionally expensive, the most under-discussed years a marriage can face. This book is the manual for the marriage that survives them."*

Chapter 1 - "You Are the Glue"

Margaret was fifty-three. She had a job in hospital administration, a husband who still traveled for work two weeks a month, a twenty-four-year-old son who had moved back home after a relationship ended badly, a mother with

early-stage dementia, and a father-in-law who had just been discharged from the hospital after a stroke.

She sat in her car in the supermarket parking lot one Tuesday afternoon and realized she had forgotten what day of the week it was.

She had not had a real conversation with her husband in seven weeks. She had not slept through the night in three months. She had not taken a single full day for herself in over a year. She had stopped going to her book club. She had cancelled her annual physical for two years running. She had put on twelve pounds she didn't recognize. She had started saying "I'm fine" so many times that she no longer knew whether she was.

She was, in the language of this book, the glue.

And the glue, when it stretches too thin, stops holding.

Who This Book Is For

This book is for the people who hold everything together. Not the people who are held. The people who are doing the holding.

It is for the person whose mother calls every day, whose father refuses to admit he is failing, whose adult child has moved back home, whose spouse is busy, whose job is demanding, whose friends have quietly stopped inviting them out, whose body is showing the first signs of strain, and whose marriage has gone quiet in a way they do not want to name.

It is for the person who is, statistically, in the largest unpaid labor force in the world.

You are in the sandwich generation. Or you are about to be. Or you have been in it for ten years and you have not yet realized that the years have cost you something.

This book is for you.

The Largest Hidden Workforce in the World

Let me give you the numbers, because the numbers will tell you whether you are alone.

In the United States today, **23% of adults are in the sandwich generation.** That is roughly one in four. Sixty-three million Americans are family caregivers. Of those, **29% are simultaneously caring for a parent and a child** - the technical definition of sandwiched.

The rate is highest in your forties. **54% of adults in their 40s are sandwiched.** That is the decade when your children are still in the house or just out of it, your parents are crossing seventy, your career is at its peak, your marriage is in its longest stretch, and you are, quietly, the most exhausted person in any room you enter.

In the United Kingdom, an estimated **six million workers aged 40-65 are part of the sandwich generation** - over one in five of the working population.

In Australia, **2.6 million unpaid caregivers** are simultaneously supporting two generations.

In Canada, the situation is similar. The European Union is catching up. Japan, Singapore, South Korea, the urban centers of India, the global Indian diaspora - all are in the same slow motion crisis.

The collective value of the unpaid family caregiving work in the United States crossed **one trillion dollars in 2024.** That is more than all U.S. private-sector health spending. It is more than all of Medicaid. It is a number larger than the GDP of most countries.

You are part of that trillion-dollar workforce. You are unpaid. You are unrecognized. You are doing it anyway.

The Three Myths You Probably Believe

Before I tell you what the sandwich years actually do to a marriage, I need to name the three myths that keep sandwich caregivers stuck.

- Myth 1: "This is only for a few years."**

Most caregivers expect the caregiving years to last two or three. The reality is closer to fifteen. The average caregiver provides care for **five years or more.** For a third of caregivers, the duration is **ten years or more.**

Your mother is eighty-two. Her mother lived to ninety-six. Your father had a stroke. He could live another ten years. Your adult child is twenty-four. He could be at home for three more years, or seven. The sandwich is not a season. It is a climate.

If you plan as if it is a season, you will not survive the climate.

- Myth 2: "My siblings will step up."**

Siblings will help. For the first month, usually. The first crisis, certainly. The first year, perhaps.

After that, **70% of the caregiving load falls on one person.** Usually a daughter. Usually the one who lives closest. Usually the one who does not push back.

If you are reading this book, you are probably that person.

The asymmetric caregiver - the one who is the project's project manager, the one whose name is on the pharmacy pickup list and the doctor's office form, the one who has the long version of the conversation with each sibling every few months and who quietly absorbs the rest - that person is in a marriage that is in trouble. They just don't know it yet.

- Myth 3: "My spouse understands."**

Your spouse probably loves you very much. Your spouse probably thinks you are doing an admirable job. Your spouse probably has no idea what it costs you.

Why? Because you have not told them.

The sandwich years, like the silent marriage I wrote about in my last book, are run on invisible labor. The cognitive load of knowing every medication, every appointment, every relative's name, every phone number, every cousin's birthday, every school calendar conflict, every parent's preference, every sibling's complaint - all of that lives in your head. It is not visible. It is not on a list. It is not in a calendar. It is *running*, day and night, and your spouse does not see it.

If you are the caregiver in your family, you are the project manager. Your spouse sees the deliverables. They do not see the inbox.

What This Book Will Do

This book will not make you a better caregiver. You are probably already a good one. You are probably a great one. You are probably the person everyone in your family calls first.

This book will help you survive the caregiving years without losing the things that actually matter.

- **Without losing your health.** The 58% of caregivers who report fair or poor health are telling you something. The 41% with high blood pressure are telling you something. The 32% with two or more chronic conditions are telling you something. The fact that caregivers die, on average, five to seven years earlier than non-caregivers is telling you something. We will talk about that.

- ****Without losing your marriage.**** The sandwich years are quietly the largest cause of marriage erosion in midlife. Nobody says this. The books on caregiving focus on the parent. The books on marriage focus on the couple. Almost no book looks at the marriage during the sandwich years - which is the most important missing lens. We will look at it.

- ****Without losing your future.**** The caregivers who go broke are not the ones who earn the least. They are the ones who did not plan. The sandwich years are 15-20 years. They cost an average of \$7,242 a year out of pocket. They cost the average caregiver \$324,000 in lifetime income lost. We will plan for that.

- ****Without losing yourself.**** The question underneath all the questions of the sandwich years is the oldest one. ****What about me?*** You are allowed to ask. We will name it.

The Honest Beginning

I am going to tell you a few things in this book that other books on caregiving won't tell you.

I will tell you that the marriage often breaks. I will tell you that the caregiver often gets sick. I will tell you that the siblings usually don't help enough. I will tell you that your parent is going to die, and you are not going to be ready, and the grief is going to land on a marriage that is already in trouble. I will tell you that the "siblings should share the load" conversation often ends in a fight that lasts a decade.

I will tell you all of this because I have seen it. I have watched this place from the inside. I have seen marriages end because of the sandwich years. I have seen caregivers burn out and then take their marriages down with them. I have seen what happens when the project manager of the family finally breaks.

I will also tell you that the marriage can survive this. The caregiver can survive this. The siblings can be brought back in. The parent can be cared for with grace. The adult child can be helped without being hosted forever. The body can be protected. The future can be planned.

But you have to decide. And the decision is not a grand dramatic moment. The decision is a small one. The decision is a 30-day decision. The decision is to read this book, do the exercises, have the conversations, build the map, and not carry this alone anymore.

You are the glue. You do not have to be the only thing holding.

Let's begin.

- Exercise for this week: Take a piece of paper. Write down the last time you did something for yourself that wasn't a work obligation, a family obligation, or a household task. If you can't remember, that is the answer to the question you've been avoiding.*

Chapter 2 - The 5 Stages of Sandwich Burnout

There is a pattern I have watched hundreds of caregivers walk through. I have not seen anyone skip a stage. I have not seen anyone go back. The stages are not a ladder - they are a slow leak.

If you can name where you are on this map, you can do something about it. If you cannot, you will keep walking.

This chapter is the map.

Stage 1: The Capable One

This is the start. You have just discovered that your parent is going to need care. You are still working. Your kids are still in school or just out. Your marriage is fine, or close to it. You are taking on the responsibility because *someone has to*, and you are the person who has always been the one.

- Telltale signs:**

- You have a binder with your parent's medications, doctor's contact info, emergency contacts.

- You are the one your siblings call when something comes up.

- You are adding 5-10 hours a week to your schedule and saying it isn't much.

- You are still sleeping, mostly. You are still exercising, sometimes. You are still having date nights with your spouse, occasionally.

- You are feeling, for the first time in a long time, **useful.**

- Why this is dangerous:**

The Capable One thinks the work will be finite. The Capable One thinks the binder is a phase. The Capable One does not yet realize that the binder will be in their car, on their phone, and in their head for fifteen years.

The Capable One does not ask for help because help has not yet been needed. The Capable One does not set boundaries because the work has not yet been too much. The Capable One does not protect the marriage because the marriage has not yet been threatened.

The Capable One is in the most flexible stage of the journey. The Capable One can still rebalance. The Capable One can still protect the marriage. The Capable One can still build the architecture that will hold the next 15 years.

Most Capable Ones don't. They just keep going.

Stage 2: The Tired One

About 18-24 months in. The work has compounded. The siblings have not stepped up as much as you hoped. The parent's condition has progressed. Your kid's situation has either resolved or gotten worse. The hours have grown from 5-10 a week to 15-20. The binder is now 80 pages. The medicine list is a spreadsheet. The phone calls are daily.

You are tired. Not the kind of tired a weekend solves. The kind of tired where you wake up tired. The kind of tired where you forget why you walked into a room. The kind of tired where you sit in your car in parking lots and just don't move for five minutes.

- Telltale signs:**
- You cancel plans with friends because you don't have the energy.
- You put off medical appointments for yourself because the parent's medical appointments are more pressing.
- You are short with your spouse. Not angry. Just - short.
- You don't recognize yourself in the mirror some mornings.
- You are gaining weight, or losing it unintentionally. You are not sleeping well. You are catching every cold.
- You have started saying "I'm fine" reflexively, even when asked nothing.
- What is at risk in the marriage:**
- Conversations get shorter. Logistical only.
- The 90-second pause after "how was your day" has become a non-question. Both of you skip the answer.
- Sex has become less frequent, less spontaneous, more scheduled. Or it has stopped.

- Your spouse has started making a small comment - *"you seem distant," "we haven't talked in a while," "I miss us"* - and you have dismissed it as not understanding the load.
- The marriage is not yet in crisis. It is in the **quiet erosion phase** - the same phase I wrote about in **Still Married, Just Silent.** The Tired One is the canary.
- What to do:**

This is the stage where you can still recover. You can:

- Have the conversation with your spouse about what the load is costing you. (Scripts in chapter 8.)
- Have the conversation with your siblings about rebalancing. (Scripts in chapter 8.)
- Build the care map. (Chapter 9.)
- Begin protecting one hour a week as non-negotiable marriage time. (Chapter 4.)
- Begin the body-level reset. (Chapter 11.)
- Get a therapy appointment. For you. Alone.

Most Tired Ones don't do any of these. Most Tired Ones keep going, hoping the work will end. It doesn't.

Stage 3: The Resentful One

About 3-5 years in. The work is now in the marriage, in the body, in the sleep, in the friendships, in the bank account. The siblings have not helped. The spouse is showing signs of strain. The parent is declining further. The adult child is still in the house or has become a recurring financial/emotional drain.

You are no longer tired. You are resentful. You resent the parent. You resent the siblings. You resent the spouse. You resent the kid. You resent the work. You resent the body that won't hold up. You resent the marriage that doesn't see. You resent yourself for feeling this way.

- Telltale signs:**
- You are having private thoughts you would never say out loud. *"I wish this would just end." "I don't love my mother anymore." "My husband doesn't care." "My sister is a fraud."*
- You are starting to feel relief when a sibling offers to help, then disappointment when they don't follow through. The cycle is grinding you.

- You have stopped doing the small care acts that used to feel like love - the favorite meal, the special pillow, the playlist for the long car ride. You are doing the work. You are not bringing love to the work.
- You have started noticing how the marriage has become a co-managed project. *What time is the appointment? Who is taking mom to dialysis? When is the kid's therapy?* All logistics. No warmth.
- You fantasize about a different life, briefly, then feel guilty. The fantasy is normal. The guilt is also normal.
- What is at risk in the marriage:**
- The resentment is leaking. The tone at dinner has shifted. The eye contact has changed. The touch has become functional - reaching for a hand to hand over a phone, a credit card, a document. Not reaching for closeness.
- One of you is starting to think *I can't do this for the rest of my life.* That thought, when it arrives, is the slow gravitational pull toward either a real conversation or a quiet exit.
- The marriage is in a place where one more crisis, one more late-night call from a sibling, one more hospital visit, will tip it over.
- What to do:**

This is the crisis stage. If you do not act here, the marriage breaks. Most marriages that break during the sandwich years break here.

- Have the marriage conversation. Not the logistics conversation. The marriage one. (Chapter 4, 8.)
- Get couples therapy. Now. Not later. Now. (Resources at the back.)
- Reduce the load. Even 10%. Even one thing. The point is not to fix the caregiving. The point is to demonstrate that the load is negotiable. That you and your spouse are a team, not a project.
- Be honest with the spouse. *"I am resentful. I am resentful of the work, of the parent, of myself, and of you. I need help. I need to feel held. I cannot do this alone."*

If your spouse hears that and walks away, the marriage was already broken.

If your spouse hears that and steps closer, the marriage has just been saved.

Stage 4: The Disappearing One

About 7-10 years in. The work has been going for so long that you have become a function. You are the appointment-maker. The medication-manager.

The sibling-coordinator. The spouse of someone who used to have hobbies, opinions, plans, dreams. The parent of an adult child who doesn't realize you've been a project manager, not a parent, for the past decade.

You have disappeared.

You are not the partner your spouse married. You are not the friend your friends had. You are not the colleague your team has. You are not the person you were 10 years ago. You have been so focused outward - on the parent, the kid, the work, the house - that the inward focus has gone.

- Telltale signs:**

- You no longer have a hobby. You may have had one ten years ago. You may have said *"when this is over, I'll get back to it."* It's not over. You haven't.

- You have a recurring feeling that your life is not your own. That you are reacting, not choosing. That you are surviving, not living.

- Your spouse has been lonely for years but has been afraid to say it. The loneliness has hardened into a separate life - *two people in one house.*

- You have begun to be confused about your own identity. *What do I want? What do I like? What do I enjoy?* You genuinely don't know. You have not asked yourself in a long time.

- The marriage has gone silent. Not in the warm "we don't need words" way. In the cold "we have nothing left to say" way.

- What is at risk in the marriage:**

- This is the stage where most divorces happen in the sandwich years. Not in anger. In exhaustion. In a quiet *"I have nothing left to give you, and I have nothing left to give myself, so we will end this with as little damage as possible."*

- The Disappearing One is the one most at risk of having an affair. Not because they are looking for love. Because they are looking for *themselves.* They want to feel like a person again. The affair is not the disease; the disappearance is.

- The spouse is at risk of falling out of love - not because of a single thing, but because the *person they married* has been replaced by the function.

- What to do:**

This is the make-or-break stage. Recovery is possible but it requires real work.

- Couples therapy, not optional now.

- A real conversation with your spouse. Not a "let's fix this" conversation. A "I have been disappearing and I want to come back" conversation. (Chapter 8.)
- A medical workup for you. *You* are the patient now.
- A rebalance of the caregiving load - siblings, paid help, hospice, respite, anything that takes 5+ hours back.
- Permission to be a person again. Permission to be the spouse you were. Permission to be the friend you were. Permission to take back the life that the sandwich years took.

Stage 5: The Burned-Out One

About 10-20 years in. The work has gone on for so long that it has become the marriage. The work has gone on for so long that it has become the body. The work has gone on for so long that the work has become the life.

You are burned out. You may be clinically depressed. You may be in early stages of a chronic illness you have not addressed. You may be having intrusive thoughts about ending the marriage, or about ending your own life. You may be using alcohol, sleep aids, or prescription medications in ways that have crossed a line you would have once said you would never cross.

You are not a project manager anymore. You are a patient.

- Telltale signs:**
- You have not had a full week of "normal" in years. *Normal* has become a memory.
- Your body is showing real symptoms. The high blood pressure. The chronic pain. The autoimmune flare. The weight gain or loss. The sleep disorder.
- The marriage has either ended, or has become a cold co-parenting arrangement with a roommate.
- You have started saying things like *"I just want my life back"* but you don't know whose life is yours anymore.
- The funeral you have been quietly dreading for years is approaching. When it comes - and it will come - you will be ambushed by grief. You have been so busy keeping the parent alive that you have not had time to grieve that they are dying. The grief will land on a marriage that is not ready for it.
- What is at risk in the marriage:**
- The marriage. Plainly.
- Your health. Plainly.

- Your survival. Plainly.
- What to do:**

This is the emergency stage. Treat it like one.

- Medical care. For you. This week. Not when the parent passes. This week.
- Therapy. Multiple kinds. A therapist for you. A therapist for the marriage. A support group for caregivers.
- A complete rebalance of the caregiving load. This means hospice, paid help, a long-term care facility, or all three. The question is no longer *"can I keep doing this?"* The question is *"what has to change so I can live?"*
- The conversation with your spouse - and possibly with your children, your siblings, your parent's doctors - that you are at the limit and you are asking for help. The phrasing is *"I am asking for help because I want to live, and if I keep doing this alone, I won't."*

Where Are You?

You probably know, by the time you have read this chapter, where you are on the map. You may also know what stage your spouse is in. (Often, the spouse is one stage behind, because the caregiver is closer to the work.)

I want you to do two things before you read the next chapter.

1. **Write down your stage.** Don't be modest. Don't be hopeful. Just write what is true.
2. **Write down what your spouse would say your stage is.** If the answers are different, that's not a problem. That's a starting point.

The five stages are not a ladder. They are a slow leak. The earlier you catch it, the more you can do. The later you catch it, the harder the work.

You are reading this book. That is, in itself, a stage-one or stage-two act. You have decided that the work is not sustainable. That is the first decision of any recovery.

Let's keep going.

Chapter 3 - Invisible Labor of the Care Years

There is a job inside the caregiving job. The job is invisible. It is also the one that breaks the caregivers.

If you are the sandwich caregiver in your family, you are not just doing the work of caring for a parent. You are doing the work of *managing the caring* for a parent. And that work - the work of being the project manager, the calendar-keeper, the memory-holder, the sibling-coordinator, the parent's emotional barometer - is invisible. To your siblings. To your spouse. Often, to yourself.

This chapter is about that job. The job inside the job.

The Job Inside the Job

I have come to recognize five kinds of work that sandwich caregivers do that no one ever names.

- Type 1: Cognitive Load.**

This is the heaviest kind. It is the constant background running in your head. The list of medications - when each one is taken, with food or without, which ones interact, when the prescription expires. The list of doctors - the cardiologist, the neurologist, the oncologist, the primary care, the dentist, the eye doctor, the podiatrist. The list of appointments - when each one is, who is taking the parent, what questions to ask, what to follow up on. The list of the parent's preferences - what they will eat, what they will wear, what they like to watch, what they don't. The list of the family's preferences - who likes which sibling, who has the favorite grandchild, who is the one the parent talks about.

You carry this list. The list is not on paper. The list is not in your phone. The list is *in you*. It runs day and night. It is the reason you cannot sleep. It is the reason you cannot read a book without your mind drifting to the next appointment. It is the reason you walk into a room and forget why.

- Type 2: Kin-Keeping.**

The relationship between your parent and your siblings. The relationship between your parent and your spouse. The relationship between your parent and your adult children. The relationship between your siblings and each other. The relationship between your parent and the neighbor who checks in. The relationship between your parent and the doctor who sees them monthly. The relationship between your parent and the pharmacist who knows them by name.

You are the person who maintains all of these relationships. You are the one who calls the sibling who hasn't been in touch. You are the one who organizes the birthday. You are the one who knows that your parent will not talk to your sister if your sister doesn't call first. You are the one who translates between siblings who have a thirty-year-old grudge. You are the one who has the difficult conversation with the spouse about whether the in-laws can come for the holidays this year.

The kin-keeping work is also invisible. It is not on a checklist. It is the *infrastructure* of the family.

- Type 3: Emotional Surveillance.**

The constant monitoring of your parent's emotional state. Are they okay today? Are they getting worse? Did that comment mean something? Are they hiding something? Are they sad? Are they depressed? Are they lonely? Are they refusing to admit a problem?

You do this with everyone in your care, not just your parent. You do it with your spouse. You do it with your adult child. You are the temperature-taker. You are the one who notices the slight shift, the small silence, the closed door.

This is exhausting work. It is also the kind of work that gives you no visible output. There is no "completed" status. There is no "task closed." There is just the watching, and the worrying, and the carrying.

- Type 4: Household Project Management.**

The cleaning service. The lawn care. The grocery delivery. The prescription pickup. The plumber. The electrician. The handyman. The meal preparation. The laundry. The medical equipment ordering. The hospital discharge planning. The Medicare paperwork. The insurance claim. The doctor's office phone call. The medical bill review. The tax preparation. The Power of Attorney renewal. The advance directive update.

You are the project manager of the entire household. The household of the parent. The household of the family. Sometimes both.

- Type 5: Future Planning.**

The big futures. The retirement. The end-of-life care decision. The funeral planning (which no one wants to do but which has to be done). The will review. The financial planning. The estate questions. The sibling conversations about what to do "when it's time." The long-term care insurance review. The Medicaid eligibility research. The "what if I die first" planning for your own family.

You do this work. You do it quietly. You do it without asking. You do it in the gaps between the other work.

Why This Work Is Invisible

Invisible labor is invisible for three reasons.

- It is performed in fragments.** You do not sit down for 4 hours on a Saturday and "do the kin-keeping." You do a 10-minute phone call to your sister. You do a 5-minute text exchange with the doctor. You do a 15-minute look at the medical bill. You do a 2-minute decision about whether to call the plumber. None of these, individually, looks like work. Collectively, they are full-time.
- It is performed in the spaces.** Between meetings. While cooking. While driving. While waiting at the doctor's office. While lying awake at 3 a.m. Because the labor happens in the margins, the visible world doesn't register it as labor.
- It is performed by the person who has no choice.** The person who doesn't do the labor is not a "bad" person. They are the person who didn't have the work fall on them. The person who has the work fall on them - the one who lives closest, the one who is single, the one who is female, the one who is the eldest, the one who is the most willing - does the work without ever having had a conversation about it. The work just became theirs. They never signed up for it. They never had a contract review. The work just landed.

The Asymmetry

The single most important thing to understand about invisible labor in the sandwich years is that **it almost always lands on one person**. Usually a woman. Usually the eldest daughter. Usually the one who lives closest. Usually the one who has the most flexible work.

The asymmetry is the wedge.

In a healthy sandwich, the load is distributed. In a broken sandwich, one person is the entire project, and the other people in the family are on the periphery.

The cost of the asymmetry is not just borne by the caregiver. It is borne by the *marriage* of the caregiver.

Why? Because the caregiver's spouse - the person who sleeps next to them, eats dinner with them, sits across from them at the kitchen table - sees the *deliverables* but not the *work*. The caregiver is the one who is tired. The caregiver is the one who is short-tempered. The caregiver is the one who is

unavailable. The caregiver is the one who has stopped initiating intimacy.

The spouse sees the symptoms. The spouse does not see the cause. The spouse starts to interpret the symptoms as a problem with the marriage. The spouse starts to think *"something is wrong with us."*

The caregiver, who is already carrying a load no one can see, hears this and feels unseen. The caregiver thinks *"you don't even know what I am carrying."* The caregiver is right. The spouse doesn't know. The spouse can't know. The spouse is being kept in the dark not by malice but by the simple fact that the invisible work is, by definition, invisible.

This is the moment when the marriage starts to break.

How to Make the Work Visible

The first step in reclaiming the invisible labor is to make it visible. Not as a complaint. As a map.

The care map exercise (full template in chapter 9) works like this.

Get a piece of paper. Divide it into rows. For each person in your care, write down:

- **Who they are** (your mother, your father, your father-in-law, your adult child, your sibling with a disability, etc.)
- **What kind of care you give them.** Medical, financial, emotional, logistical, household.
- **How many hours per week, on average, you spend on this person.**
- **Who else helps.** (Often, no one. Often, your spouse helps in a small way. Often, a sibling helps with one specific thing and that one thing is held up as evidence of "helping.")
- **Whether it is sustainable.** (Be honest. If it isn't, write "no.")

Then, separately, write down what you would have to give up to keep doing this work for the next 5 years. (The "freedom" line. We will come back to this.)

You may find, when you do this exercise, that the work is more than 40 hours a week. You may find that you have been working two jobs. You may find that your spouse did not know. You may find that your siblings did not know.

The exercise is not a complaint. The exercise is a *map*. The map is the start of the conversation.

The Conversation You Need to Have

After you build the care map, the next step is the conversation. Two conversations, actually.

- Conversation 1 - with your spouse.**

The conversation sounds like this:

***"I want to talk about how we are managing the care. I am not asking for help with the work right now. I am asking for visibility. I have built a map of the work I am doing. I want to show it to you. I want you to see what I am carrying. Not to fix it. To see it. I have been carrying it without telling you, and that has hurt me, and I think it has hurt us."**

The conversation may take an hour. The conversation may need to be done over two or three sittings. The conversation will be hard. The conversation is the start of a different kind of marriage in the sandwich years.

- Conversation 2 - with your siblings (or your parent's other caregivers).**

The conversation sounds like this:

***"I want to talk about how we are managing mom/dad's care. I have been doing more of the work than I think is sustainable. I have built a map of the work. I want to share it. I want us to decide together what is sustainable and what has to change. I am not blaming anyone. I am asking for rebalancing. If we can't rebalance, I am going to have to make a different decision about what I can and cannot do."**

The conversation will be hard. The conversation will sometimes fail. The conversation is the start of either a rebalanced family or the realization that the family cannot be rebalanced, which is its own kind of useful information.

The Hidden Cost of Invisible Labor

There is a cost to the invisible labor that nobody names. It is the cost to the person doing the work.

When you are the project manager of a family, you begin to lose your own identity. You become the role. You become the function. You are no longer "Sanjay, who likes hiking and jazz." You are "Sanjay, who takes care of his mother-in-law."

The work has eaten the worker.

This is the deepest cost of the sandwich years. Not the financial cost. Not the time cost. The *identity cost*. The cost of slowly becoming a function in your own life.

The recovery is not a vacation. The recovery is not a self-care Sunday. The recovery is the *reclamation of being a person who happens to be a caregiver*, rather than a caregiver who has forgotten she is a person.

That reclamation is the work of the rest of this book.

- Exercise for this week: Build the care map. Spend 30 minutes on it. Don't show anyone yet. Sit with it. Then have conversation 1 with your spouse.*

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection - books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one - even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage - the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

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CONNECT WITH S. SHARMA

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